

ROBERT J. HIGHAM

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Security engineering leader with 20+ years building detection, threat-hunting, and security-automation capabilities across enterprise and vendor environments. Hands-on builder of production tooling, from a custom endpoint-collection agent and Python analytics platforms that returned 500+ analyst hours per month to LLM-powered alert-triage and detection-content systems. Equally comfortable architecting these systems directly and leading global detection-engineering teams protecting 1,000+ enterprise clients. Known for turning emerging AI and automation into practical, measurable security capability.

CORE COMPETENCIES

- **Detection Engineering & Threat Hunting:** Detection-as-code, rule development & tuning, MITRE ATT&CK, adversary emulation, threat-hunting program design, SIEM / EDR / XDR, false-positive reduction
- **Security Automation & AI Tooling:** Python, LLM & agentic tooling, alert-triage automation, custom agents & endpoint collectors, ML detection (random/isolation forest, PySpark), Jira / Confluence API integration
- **Security Operations & Incident Response:** SOC operations, incident command, runbook & SOP development, cyber threat intelligence, escalation management, follow-the-sun operations
- **Engineering Leadership:** Team building & management, roadmap & backlog ownership, cross-functional delivery (Product / Sales / Support), budget & vendor management, metrics & KPIs, technical enablement & training

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

HALCYON

Remote

Detection Content Lead

January 2026 - May 2026

- Built a detection-coverage simulation tool that traced a file through the full detection pipeline, giving teams and customers a visual explanation of coverage and gap analysis.
- Built a searchable rule library with live performance metrics and interactive training material to monitor rule efficacy and accelerate technical enablement.
- Deployed an operational "digital workforce" of coding agents, report generators, and QA workflows to assess rule style, resilience, and pipeline risk.

GARTNER, INC.

Irving, TX

Director of Security Operations

June 2025 - January 2026

- Built an LLM-powered alert-triage assistant (Azure GPT) integrating Jira, runbooks, SOPs, and a Confluence tools inventory to guide analysts through investigations, auto-enriching each alert with user, device, and prior-ticket context.
- Built a Jira ticket-grading agent that scored analyst investigation notes and fed 1:1 coaching, improving documentation quality and surfacing gaps between practice and runbooks.
- Ran US SOC operations in a follow-the-sun model and served as incident commander across detection engineering, intel, and SOC teams.

SECUREWORKS, INC.

Remote

Director of Detection Engineering, Counter Threat Unit

September 2023 - February 2025

- Directed global detection research and engineering (endpoint and cloud) protecting 1,000+ enterprise clients, owning roadmap and a multi-million-dollar budget.
- Redesigned escalation and detection workflows, cutting missed critical detections from ~2% to 0.4% and escalation time-to-first-touch from 30+ days to under 5.

- Partnered with Product Engineering to ship new detections for Active Directory attack tooling (DCSync, Secretsdump, PetitPotam), including bitmask-based identification of Certipy and Rubeus.

SECUREWORKS, INC.

Remote

Senior Detection Researcher, Counter Threat Unit

November 2019 - September 2023

- Developed a Python analytics tool that processed security data at scale and returned 500+ analyst hours per month; served as de facto product manager driving adoption across service lines.
- Architected an automated threat-hunting program integrated with SIEM and EDR, with custom detection logic and automated incident-response workflows.
- Led MITRE ATT&CK evaluation preparation and adversary-emulation validation, and co-developed a PySpark ML proof-of-concept for Active Directory attack detection.

STATE FARM INSURANCE

Richardson, TX

Threat Hunting Product Owner, Security Analytics

July 2014 - November 2019

- Built GhostSweeper, a custom lightweight .NET endpoint-collection agent (encrypted self-validating sandbox, vaulted secrets) that gathered host forensic artifacts at enterprise scale when commercial tools could not, enabling hypothesis-driven hunts.
- Built State Farm's first threat-hunting capability: a data-lake platform and pre-built query library ingesting proxy, netflow, EDR, and system-event data.
- Led data-science initiatives using random forest and isolation forest models to improve command-and-control detection across large network and web datasets.

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

Education: M.S. Cybersecurity, Cyber Threat Intelligence, University of South Florida, 2018 | B.S. Information Technology, Cum Laude, Franklin University, 2007 | Technology Leadership Certificate, Cornell University (eCornell), 2025

Certifications: CISSP | OSCP | GCFA | SANS SEC588 (Cloud Penetration Testing) | CRISC | FAIR | PSPO I

SPEAKING, TRAINING & COMMUNITY LEADERSHIP

- 20+ talks at industry conferences, CISO roundtables, and webinars, including Mimecast TechConnect Summit, ElevateIT Houston, DFWSecCon, and North Texas ISSA.
- Host of the six-module "Threat Hunting 101" webcast training series; podcast guest on Forged in Security, Cybercrime Magazine's "Let's Talk SOC," and a SIEM vs. XDR panel.